

OFFICIAL RULEBOOK

SEASON 5 • 2027

FAITH • FELLOWSHIP • FITNESS

Tampa Bay Coptic Basketball League

Sanctioned under the auspices of the Coptic Orthodox Diocese of the Southern United States

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LEAGUE OVERVIEW

The Tampa Bay Coptic Basketball League (TCBL), sanctioned under the auspices of the Coptic Orthodox Diocese of the Southern United States, is an annual basketball league designed for adult men aged 18 and above across all Coptic Orthodox Churches in the Tampa Bay region. TCBL is not affiliated exclusively with any single church parish.

Our goal is to foster an environment that enhances fellowship, nurtures Christian character, and promotes physical well-being, drawing upon our three core pillars – Faith, Fellowship, and Fitness. This league is meant to move past traditional boundaries of competition, creating a space where the essence of Christian brotherhood thrives and the meaning of being a Christian man within the church is upheld.

League Format

Registration for players is done individually, with team selection considering skill level and positional aptitude. Teams are formed through a captains' draft rather than being assigned by the league. After registration, the league committee will select the top eight players based on sign-ups. These players will serve as team captains and participate in a private snake-style draft to select their teams. Captains may have coaches or advisors to assist them in making selections. The league committee reserves the right to step in if they feel competitiveness or fellowship is not being maintained during the draft.

Each team will consist of 8–10 players, depending on total registration numbers. The results of the draft will be announced the same night, but captains are strictly prohibited from disclosing the order in which players were selected. Any captain who violates this rule may lose the privilege of serving as a captain in future seasons. The league committee is managed under the guidance of Fr. Fam Nicoula.

TCBL is a yearly event, taking place each Spring. The duration of the league ranges from 8 to 10 weeks. Games will be regulated by professional referees and feature 40-minute matches divided into two 20-minute halves. The player registration fee stands at $100, which includes a dry-fit shirt and guarantees participation in at least eight games. The league commences on Sunday, January 3, 2027, and concludes on Sunday, March 14, 2027. Matches will be held over ten Sundays (with one bye week) from 3:30 PM to 8:00 PM, alternating between St. Verena and St. Reweis.

Player Cap

In view of the overwhelming interest and to ensure we maintain the quality of our league, while also respecting the limitations of our facilities, volunteer personnel, referees, and church schedules, the fifth season of the TCBL will cap player registration at 80. After the first 72 spots sold out in under an hour, the league opened a one-time expansion of 8 additional spots. We highly encourage timely registration to secure a player spot. In the event that the registration capacity is reached, or if you are unable to register in time, we invite you to remain an integral part of our community by registering as a coach or volunteer.

GYM & PLAYER RULES

1. **Prayer.** All TCBL activities start with a prayer.
2. **Conduct.** Display good sportsmanship and Christian-like behavior at all times. The gym is a sacred space. Profanity and mocking are not tolerated and may result in suspension. Swearing results in:
   a. 1st offense: Technical foul
   b. 2nd offense: Technical foul + game suspension
   c. 3rd offense: Suspension for the following game + possible removal from the league
3. **Fighting.** Any fighting or instigating will result in immediate ejection and a one-game suspension for all involved players.
4. **Facility Use.** The gym closes 30 minutes before church services and cannot be used during services.
5. **Prohibited Items.** Alcohol, tobacco, vapes, controlled substances, and weapons are not allowed. Players found with these items will be asked to leave immediately.
6. **Food and Drinks.** Only water is allowed on the gym floor. No food or other drinks are permitted.
7. **Pets.** Pets are not allowed in the building.
8. **Clothing.** Appropriate clothing must be worn at all times. Jerseys must be worn to each game. No alterations to jerseys are allowed. Shorts must be an appropriate length. Only non-scuff gym shoes are allowed. Street shoes may damage the gym floor and must be removed if necessary.
9. **Jewelry.** Only medical alert bracelets and fitness trackers are allowed. All other jewelry must be removed.
10. **Vandalism.** Players are accountable for any damage to facilities or equipment. Hanging on rims or pulling on nets is prohibited.
11. **Clean-Up.** Teams must clean their bench area. Failure to do so results in a warning and a $50 fine for each subsequent offense, donated to the church.
12. **Referee Interaction.** Only a team's designated coach is allowed to speak to the referees. Other players and fans may not argue or complain to referees.
13. **Attendance and Commitment.** Missing an excessive number of games or being unresponsive may lead to a one-season suspension.
14. **Minimum Players.** A game requires at least 4 players to start. If fewer than 4 players are present at tipoff, the team forfeits the game.
15. **Injury Policy.** Teams are built to handle injuries with 8-10 players. Players cannot be added mid-season. Only injuries or illnesses early in the season may lead to a review and possible addition of a replacement player, but this is rare.
16. **Coaching.** Teams may have one non-player or one player coach, but it is not required.
17. **Heart Health (Baseline EKG).** Every player is strongly encouraged to complete a baseline EKG (heart screening) at Spiritual/Media Day. It takes only a few minutes, helps catch hidden heart conditions before the season starts, and gives each player a baseline to keep with their medical records.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Q1. How long is the league and how many games are guaranteed?

TCBL is a yearly event, taking place each Spring. The duration of the league ranges from 8 to 10 weeks. Games will be regulated by professional referees and feature 40-minute matches divided into two 20-minute halves. The player registration fee stands at $100, which includes a dry-fit shirt and guarantees participation in at least eight games. The league commences on Sunday, January 3, 2027, and concludes on Sunday, March 14, 2027. Matches will be held over ten Sundays (with one bye week) from 3:30 PM to 8:00 PM, alternating between St. Verena and St. Reweis.

Q2. What are the consequences for missing games or players being unresponsive to their teams?

TCBL emphasizes the importance of fellowship and team commitment. To uphold these values, players who miss an excessive number of games, especially over consecutive seasons, or who fail to be responsive to their team may be considered for a one-season suspension. This policy helps ensure that players remain committed to their teams and the league. We understand that life events may prevent attendance at some games, so we encourage you to review the schedule before registering and coordinate with your team in advance if you anticipate missing any games.

Q3. What happens if less than 5 players on a team show up to a scheduled game?

The minimum number of players to start a scheduled game is 4 players. Under no circumstances will the game be delayed on account of tardiness. If less than 4 players are present at tipoff, the team will automatically forfeit the game. If a team has less than 4 players after tipoff (due to foul outs or injuries), the game may continue IF both teams agree to keep playing competitively.

Q4. What happens if a team is late to a scheduled game?

Under no circumstances will the game be delayed on account of tardiness. If less than 4 players are present at tipoff, the team will automatically forfeit the game.

Q5. What happens if a player does not like their team or is not receiving enough playing time?

Fellowship is one of TCBL's culture pillars. We highly encourage teams to get to know each other both as basketball players and Christian men. Team rosters are set and finalized prior to the league starting date and cannot be changed, shortened, or altered in any way. The TCBL committee will not be involved in internal team dynamics. If unfair playing time is a concern, the committee encourages teams to add a coach.

Q6. What happens if a player gets injured during the season?

Injuries are an unfortunate part of the game, but TCBL teams are designed to handle such situations. Each team consists of 8 to 10 players to maintain competitiveness and balance. Therefore, players cannot be added to a team mid-season due to injuries. However, if a player is injured early in the season (before week 3) or is unable to participate due to illness or injury and has not yet played a single game, the committee may review the situation and consider adding a replacement player. Please note that such instances are rare and handled on a case-by-case basis.

Q7. What is Spiritual/Media day?

To kick-off the TCBL season we host a Media Day! Beginning with a liturgy in the morning, the day will transition into a spiritual talk accompanied by coffee and refreshments. As the highlight, players will have the chance to meet with their teams, receive their jerseys, and partake in a photo session in their new attire. Season 5's Spiritual/Media Day will be on January 2, 2027, at St. Philopateer Coptic Orthodox Church. The liturgy will start at 8:00am and the day's events are anticipated to conclude around 1:00pm. Baseline EKG heart screenings will also be offered during Media Day, and every player is strongly encouraged to get one.

Q8. Can teams trade players?

No, teams cannot trade players. Team rosters are set and finalized before the league starts and cannot be changed or altered in any way. TCBL values kindness and promoting Christian behavior, which means striving to win with the team you were placed on. The league is not about dominating the competition, but rather about playing competitive games with your fellow brothers in a spirit of fellowship, respect, and fitness.

Q9. What happens if a player forgets their jersey or alters the official TCBL jerseys?

No alterations (e.g., cutting sleeves) of the official TCBL jerseys are allowed. If a player forgets their jersey, it is the responsibility of that player to find the same color shirt with a visible number in order to play.

Q10. Why are jerseys not sleeveless?

In our commitment to project a professional and unified image for our league, jerseys will be short sleeved. Our intention is to ensure that the primary distinction between players is the jersey color, allowing for easy identification and maintaining the aesthetic we aim for.

Q11. What if I am late or do not attend the spiritual talks?

Faith is one of TCBL's cultural pillars. We highly encourage players to attend the spiritual talks. We do not want TCBL to be viewed simply as a basketball league, but as an opportunity to grow as a Christian man through mentoring, fellowship, and spiritual talks.

Q12. Are teams allowed to have coaches?

Yes, but it is not required. Each team is allowed to have either one non-player coach or one player coach.

Q13. Are players or fans allowed to talk to the referees during the games?

No one, under any circumstances, is allowed to argue with the referees, at any point.

Q14. Can players join a team after the season starts?

No. Team rosters are set and finalized prior to the league starting date and cannot be changed, shortened, or altered in any way.

Q15. How are teams decided?

Teams will be formed through a captains' draft. After registration, the league committee will select the top eight players based on sign-ups. These players will serve as team captains and participate in a private snake-style draft to select their teams.

Captains may have coaches or advisors to assist them in making selections. The league committee reserves the right to step in if they feel competitiveness or fellowship is not being maintained during the draft.

Each team will consist of 8–10 players, depending on total registration numbers. The results of the draft will be announced the same night, but captains are strictly prohibited from disclosing the order in which players were selected. Any captain who violates this rule may lose the privilege of serving as a captain in future seasons.

Q16. What happens if teams leave trash on their bench?

Respect for the facility and the church is a priority. In the event that the team's bench area is left a mess, as determined by the Abouna of the church and the committee, each team will be issued a one-time warning followed by a $50/team fine at the second offense. This fine will be allocated as a donation to the church where the offense occurred. It is the responsibility of each team member to hold their teammates accountable, regardless of attendance at the game.

Q17. Can family, friends, and fans cheer or boo the teams during games?

All fans are encouraged to cheer for their teams and support their players enthusiastically. However, booing or displaying negative behavior towards any team, players, or officials is forbidden and may result in removal from the games. We aim to maintain a positive and respectful atmosphere at all games.

IN-GAME PROCEDURES

1. **Clock:**
   a. Each game will consist of two 20-minute halves.
   b. Unless it is a time-out, the clock will not stop until the final 10 minutes of the 2nd half.
      i. If the score differential is over 30 points, the clock will not stop.
   c. Teams will have two 30-second timeouts per half.
      i. Timeouts do not carry over to the 2nd half.
      ii. The referee will decide whether or not the ball advances following a timeout.
2. **Overtime:**
   a. Overtime is a total of 4 minutes.
      i. Each team will be allowed one 30-second timeout.
   b. Double Overtime is a total of 2 minutes.
      i. Each team will be allowed one 30-second timeout.
   c. Each subsequent overtime will be 1 minute with no timeouts.
3. **Fouls:**
   a. Players receiving five (5) personal fouls in one game will be disqualified from the game.
   b. All foul calls are judgment calls of the referees and will not be questioned.
      i. Technical foul: There will be (2) two shots awarded and possession of the ball.
         1. Any player receiving two technical fouls will be ejected from the remainder of the game.
      ii. Two technical fouls in two games on the same day will result in a one-game suspension.
      iii. Flagrant foul: There will be (2) two free throws awarded.
         1. Flagrant “1” (FFP1) – unnecessary contact committed by a player against an opponent.
            a. The opposing team is awarded two (2) free throws and possession.
            b. Any player who commits two Flagrant “1” Fouls in a single game will be automatically ejected from that game.
         2. Flagrant “2” (FFP2) – unnecessary and excessive contact committed by a player against an opponent.
            a. The opposing team is awarded two (2) free throws and possession and the player committing the foul is automatically ejected.
            b. Any player who commits a Flagrant “2” Fouls will be suspended for the next game.
   c. Teams are awarded a one-and-one situation when the opposing team reaches the sixth (6) team foul in a half, and a double bonus for eight (8) fouls in a half. If overtime occurs, the team fouls will carry over.
4. **Free Throws:**
   a. During free-throw shooting, all players including the ones that are not lined up along the key are allowed to enter the key when the ball is released from the hand of the shooter, except for the shooter who must wait for the ball to hit the rim.
   b. During free throw shooting, the shooter is allowed 10-seconds to shoot each free throw.
5. **Substitutions:**
   a. A substitution is when you swap a player from the bench with a player on the basketball court.

i. This is used to allow players to rest and recover throughout the game as well as give all players on the team a chance to participate.

b. Teams are allowed to make an unlimited amount of substitutions throughout the game.

c. Teams are allowed to substitute their players on and off the court in any dead-ball situation (after fouls, violations, timeouts, free-throws, etc).

d. A substitution is called by asking the scoring table for a 'sub' and then waiting for a stoppage in play where the referee will give teams time to substitute players.

e. Do not substitute players without waiting for the referee to signal for you to do so or it will result in a technical foul on your team.

f. All players are required to check in at the scores table before entering the game.

6. Scoring:

a. Each free-throw is worth one point.

b. Each field goal (mid range shot, layup, post move, etc) is worth two points.

c. Each shot made from behind the three-point line is worth three points (Note: If any part of the player's foot is on the three-point line when shooting, the shot will be worth 2 points.)